

What to check when you finally stand inside the house.

Thirty minutes. No tools but your phone.

You will be nervous, the agent will be polite, and you will forget half of what you meant to ask. Print this. Hold it. Tick as you go.

Anything marked **RED FLAG** means: stop, and get a structural survey before you make an offer.

Before you go in — from the road

- ☐ **Stand back and look at the ridge line of the roof.** Sight along it. A gentle dip is common in old houses. **RED FLAG:** the dip continues down into the eaves, or the ridge is visibly S-shaped — that is the frame, not the tiles.
- ☐ **Photograph all four sides** from the same distance. You will want these later, and the agent will not send them to you.
- ☐ **Look at where the roof meets the walls.** Green or black staining down an outside wall means water has been running there for years.
- ☐ **How does the road reach the house?** Measure the width of the road at its narrowest with your feet (one pace $\approx$ 75 cm). **RED FLAG:** under about 4 m — ask whether the lot can be rebuilt on at all.
- ☐ **Is there a gap between this house and the next?** Zero-gap terraced houses (nagaya) share walls and cannot always be renovated independently.

The frame — the part you cannot fix cheaply

- ☐ **Put your phone on the floor with the level app open.** Do this in at least three rooms, on both floors. Write down the numbers. **RED FLAG:** the slope is more than about 1 cm per metre, or every room tilts the *same* way — that points at the foundation.
- ☐ **Walk the whole floor slowly, heel to toe.** Listen. Bounce gently. **RED FLAG:** soft or springy floor near the kitchen, bath or toilet — water has been leaking under it, probably for years.
- ☐ **Go outside and find where a post meets the foundation stone.** Press the wood hard with your thumb. **RED FLAG:** your nail goes in, the surface is powdery, or there are small round holes — rot or termites.
- ☐ **Tap the posts with your knuckle** at ankle height and at chest height. A hollow, dull sound low down where it was solid higher up is a bad sign.
- ☐ **Ask to see the attic (小屋裏).** Take a photo straight up with the flash on. You are looking for daylight, black staining, and sagging beams. **Old black stains** = long-term leak. **Fresh brown stains** = leaking now.

The one thing people get wrong: a beautiful interior can sit on a ruined frame, and an ugly interior can sit on a perfect one. Finishes are cheap. The frame is not. Spend your thirty minutes on the frame.

Water, air and animals

- ☐ **Turn on every tap.** If the water is off, ask when it was last run. Note the colour of the first water out.
- ☐ **Flush the toilet if you can.** Ask whether the house is on **public sewer** or a **septic tank (浄化槽)**. This matters more than it sounds — a septic tank carries legal inspection duties every year **even when nobody lives there**.
- ☐ **Open the cupboard under the sink and the bathroom access panel.** Photograph the pipes. Look for green corrosion and fresh water marks.
- ☐ **Stand still in the middle of the house and smell.** Damp earth = ground moisture. Sour or sweet mustiness = mould behind the finishes. Ammonia = animals.
- ☐ **Look for droppings** along the edges of the attic and under the veranda. Rats, martens (ten) and civets are common in rural Kyoto houses.
- ☐ **Open and close three sliding doors.** If they jam or swing open on their own, the opening is out of square — which takes you back to the frame.

The paperwork questions — ask while you are standing there

Show this table to the agent. The Japanese is there so you do not have to pronounce it.

1. Is this lot rebuildable? Does it meet the road-frontage rule? If the answer is no, the building can never be replaced — only repaired.	この土地は再建築可能ですか。接道義務を満たしていますか。
2. Is the house one storey or two, and what is the total floor area? This decides whether a 2025 building-confirmation applies to your renovation.	この家は平屋ですか、2階建てですか。延床面積は何平米ですか。
3. Is the registered owner the person selling it? Has the inheritance been registered? Unregistered inheritance is the classic akiya trap — multiple heirs must all agree.	登記名義人は売主本人ですか。相続登記は済んでいますか。
4. Public sewer or septic tank? Is the water supply public? Ask for the last inspection record if it is a septic tank.	下水道ですか、浄化槽ですか。水道は公営ですか。
5. What is your commission, in writing, before I view anything else? Since July 2024 an agent may charge up to ¥330,000 on a property under ¥8M — but only with your written consent in advance . Without it the cap is ¥110,000.	仲介手数料はいくらですか。書面でいただけますか。

After the viewing, before you sleep on it: write down the three worst things you saw, in your own words, while they are fresh. In our experience the thing people talk themselves out of on the train home is the thing that costs them the most later.

What this checklist cannot do

It cannot tell you what the repairs will cost, whether the frame is sound under the plaster, where the boundary runs, or who legally owns the house. Those need a survey, a registry search and, in the end, somebody standing in front of the building on your behalf.

If you want the desk-research half of that — zoning, rebuild status, the 2025 permit line, hazard exposure, holding costs and what we could *not* find — that is what our ¥3,000 report is. Send us a listing and we will tell you what the data says, including when the data says walk away.